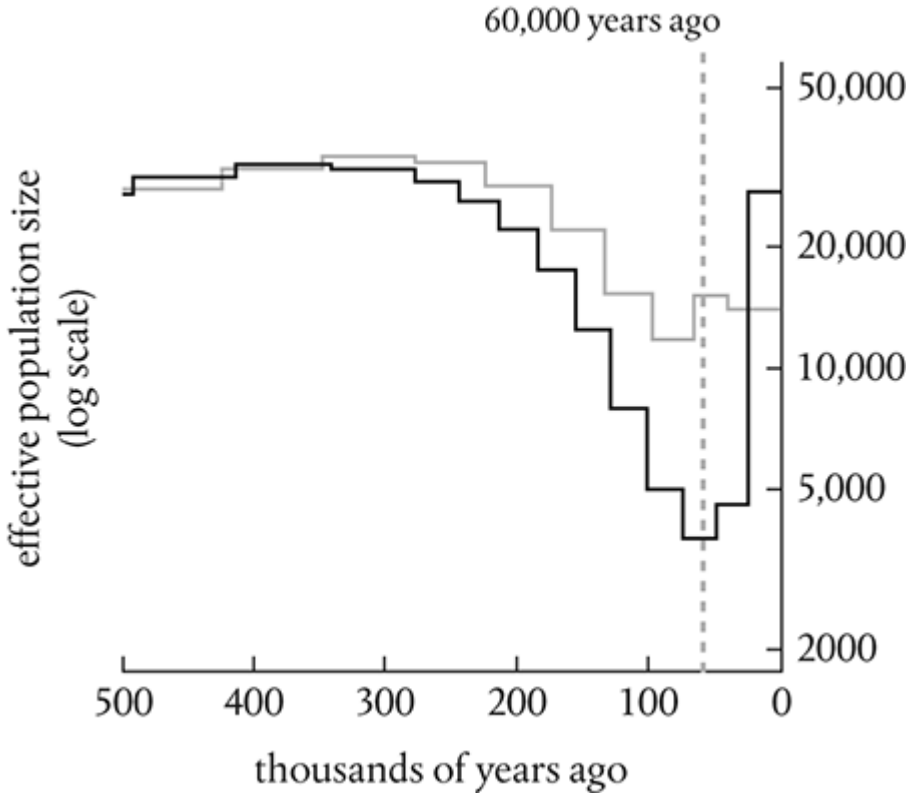


From R. Dawkins and Y. Wong (2006) *The Ancestor's Tale*, 2nd edition Image courtesy of Y. Wong

The black line shows the estimates of effective population size at various times in history based upon my genome (coalescences between genes from my father and my mother). It shows that the effective population size among my ancestral population plummeted around 60,000 years ago. The grey line shows the equivalent pattern derived from the genome of a Nigerian man. It also shows a drop in population around the same time, but a less dramatic one. Perhaps whatever calamity caused the drop was less severe in Africa than in Eurasia.

Incidentally Yan was my undergraduate pupil in New College, Oxford, before I started learning more from him than he learns from me. He then became a graduate student of Alan Grafen, whom I had also tutored as an undergraduate, who subsequently became my graduate student and whom I have described as being now my intellectual mentor. So Yan is both my student and my grandstudent—a neat memetic analogue to the point I was making earlier about how we are related in multiple ways—although the direction of cultural inheritance is more complicated than this simple formulation implies.